

Criteria for Certified Professional for Software Architecture (CPSA)[®]

Expert Level

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Training Provider

A training provider must fulfill the following criteria to get the accreditation from iSAQB:

Criterion	Details	Evidence
iSAQB FL or AL	The organization must be accredited for the Foundation Level and/or the Advanced Level of the iSAQB®.	iSAQB® has a list of all the organizations that are accredited.
Topic moderator	The training provider must have at least one accredited topic moderator.	The topic moderator has been accredited successfully.

Topic Moderator

The training provider provides a topic moderator for the topic working group.

A topic moderator must fulfill the following criteria to get the accreditation by iSAQB®.

Criterion	Details	Evidence
Process knowledge	A topic moderator must have knowledge of the process of Expert Level certification.	A member of the iSAQB® working group "Expert Level" conducts an interview with the applicant and checks the requested knowledge.
Social skills	A topic moderator must have social skills to be able to manage a group.	The applicant must prove one or more of the following competences: • The applicant has taken training courses or seminars, such as iSAQB® trainings or lectures at a university. • The applicant must substantiate that he has held the position of group leader for a minimum of one year, such as in an association, club, or development team.
Knowledge	A topic moderator must know enough about software architecture.	The applicant must meet the following requirements: • The applicant has at least the CPSA® Foundation Level certification. • The applicant has been working as software developer or software architect for five years.

Criteria for a New Topic

A new topic must satisfy the following criteria:

Criterion	Requirement	Description
Originality	Must	Can new insights be gained that are not yet widely known in the field of software architecture? Has the topic not yet been completely and publicly addressed (e.g., on Wikipedia)?
Relevance	Must	Is the topic of interest to a larger group of people?
Innovation	Must	Does the topic generate new ideas and knowledge of general interest?
Creativity	Shall	Does the topic demonstrate creativity, e.g., through synergies, analogies, or ideas?
Effectiveness	Shall	Can working on the topic simplify or accelerate future work in software architecture?
Problem solving	Must	Can working on the topic solve recurring and seemingly insurmountable problems in software architecture? Examples include: • Improve communication between management and software architects • Introduction of new methods, such as architecture management, Domain-Driven Design, Green IT, ...

Criteria for New Applicants

To be eligible to participate in a topic group, applicants must satisfy the following criteria:

Knowledge and Practical Experience

Applicants justify their suitability for the topic by summarizing their knowledge and practical experience and submitting certificates.

Criterion	Description
Advanced Level Certifications	Applicants must confirm that they have the Expert Level certification. The topic of the Expert Level certification must align with the specialization the applicant selected as part of the Advanced Level certification.
Practical Experience	Applicants can demonstrate at least 7 years of professional experience in the role of software architect within complex software projects. In particular, experience in architectural work that spans systems, domains, or organizational boundaries is required.
Knowledge	A solid understanding and practical application of the core concepts of software architecture, as outlined in the iSAQB curricula for the Foundation and selected Advanced Level topics. Specialization typically takes place in specific focus areas such as Domain-Driven Design, cloud architecture, architecture evaluation, documentation, or modernization, depending on the individual's expertise and project context.
Knowledge Transfer and Community Contribution	Proof of knowledge transfer or community contribution, such as training and mentoring less experienced developers or architects, leading architecture or development teams, co-developing in open-source projects, as well as through publications or presentations.
Communication Skills	Applicants must be able to communicate complex matters clearly and understandably.

Organization and General Conditions

Criterion	Description
iSAQB® can publish results	Applicants must agree that iSAQB® is allowed to publish and exploit the results of the topic group.
Willingness to travel	Applicants must confirm that they are willing to travel at their own expense to work together in the topic group. Topic working groups determine for themselves how to organize their work and whether to meet in person.
Disclosure of contact data	The applicants grant permission to iSAQB® to forward the following contact details to the other members of the topic groups: first name, last name, e-mail address, and phone number.

Why Are These Requirements Important?

The CPSA Expert Level validates technical expertise and recognizes the ability to serve as a thought leader and expert within the software architecture community. Applicants must demonstrate their capacity to contribute to the evolution of the profession, going beyond architectural practice, and show that they can tackle complex challenges in dynamic and demanding environments.

The following criteria may come into operation in the future

iSAQB® may accept individuals as candidates for the Expert Level if they meet one of the following requirement:

- People who are distinguished experts on the topic.
- Members of iSAQB® who are not permitted to participate in the iSAQB® Advanced Level Certification since they know the examination question.



The iSAQB® strategy council and the members of the iSAQB® working group "Expert Level" make a majority decision on whether a person meets one of the stated requirements.

iSAQB® can actively invite luminaries to participate in a topic group and refund the cost.

The experts must work in the chosen topic group as well. Nobody gets a certification without active and successful work on a topic.

Criteria for a Roadmap

Criterion	Requirement	Description
Objective, mission	Essential	• Are the objective and mission of the topic working group described comprehensibly?
Topic working group	Essential	• Only for topic working groups: Are the contact details of all members of the topic working group stated?
Procedure	Essential	• Are the roles and tasks of the members of the topic working group described? • Is a timetable with milestones provided? • Are the times and locations for the optional in-person meetings stated? • Are the times and resources for the virtual meetings stated? • Are the tools for electronic communication listed? • Are work packages and responsibilities defined? • Is the review process determined?
Literature	Essential	• Is there a bibliography? • Does the bibliography comprise at least 7 sources? • Are the sources of academic value?
Results	Essential	• Is the mandatory article discussed? • Is at least one additional result stated (e.g., instructions, example, ...)? • Are the form and structure discussed for each result? • Is there an attempt to present the results at at least one conference? • Is there an attempt to publish the results in at least one trade publication?

Formal Criteria for Results

Result	Requirement	Criterion
All	Essential	Origin of Content: • Was the content written independently? • Were all sources and tools used fully cited? Artificial Intelligence • Were sections generated using generative artificial intelligence marked? • Was the interaction with the artificial intelligence archived and included with the results?
Article	Essential	Does the article have the following structure and content? 1. Title a. Does the title suit the topic discussed? 2. Authors a. Are the authors named? b. Are the authors' e-mail addresses listed? 3. Abstract a. Is the problem described briefly? b. Does the abstract describe the main theses or results? c. Is the description short and understandable? 4. Introduction a. Does the introduction describe the current state of knowledge? b. Is the motivation discussed? c. Is there a description of the existing knowledge gaps that are to be filled by this academic article? d. Is there a description of the research questions that are to be answered in the article?

Result	Requirement	Criterion
		5. Main section (chapter name(s) can be chosen freely) a. Materials and methods i. Is there a description of the information sources? ii. Is there a description of the methods used to answer the research question? b. Results i. Is there a description of the findings? ii. Are the findings substantiated with sufficient plausible data? c. Discussion a. Is there a description of how the findings are interpreted? b. Is there a discussion of questions that arise from the results? c. Is there a discussion of the impacts that the findings have in practice? 6. Summary a. Is there a brief summary of all the research questions and their answers? b. Is there a brief discussion of the effects of the findings? 7. Acknowledgments a. Are supporters mentioned? 8. Conflicts of interest a. Are conflicts of interest mentioned? 9. Bibliography a. Is there a list of all the literature used? b. Is the literature cited correctly?
Additional result	Essential	• Do the form and content fulfill the purpose of the result (e.g., a new pattern according to the pattern language context, problem, solution)? • Is there a comprehensible description of the result? • Is it evident that at least two person weeks were necessary for the creation of the additional result?
Submissions	Desired	• Has the topic working group submitted a talk or a workshop to at least one conference? • Has the topic working group attempted to publish the results in at least one trade publication?

Result	Requirement	Criterion
Versioned results	Essential	The results must be submitted with a version history so that the examiners can verify that the results were actually developed by the topic workers and not generated by artificial intelligence.
Experience report	Essential	• Has each member of the topic working group submitted an experience report? • Are all the points in the experience report completed?

Content Criteria for Results

Criterion	Assessment Scheme
Importance for theory and practice	10 - Outstanding importance 08 - Important 06 - Not unimportant 04 - Rather weak importance 02 - Of low importance 00 - Absolutely no relevance
Originality and degree of innovation	10 - An important and meaningful contribution to the topic area 08 - A clear contribution to the topic area. 06 - A small contribution to the topic area. Added value may result from it in the future. 04 - There is better work on this topic. 02 - Already said many times. 00 - Contributes little or nothing at all to the topic area.
Quality of the presentation	10 - Excellently written 08 - Well written 06 - Readable 04 - Should be edited 02 - Still significant work required 00 - Unacceptable

Criteria for Participation

Criterion	Required	Description
Time Tracking	Required	Topic worker and all members of a topic working group must record their activities in a central list accessible to everyone, documenting at least the following information for each activity: • Date and duration • Activity • Work output • Names of the members who participated in the activity.
Total Work Time	Required	A topic worker and each member of a topic working group must have worked at least 40 hours on the topic.

The following criteria also apply to topic working groups:

Criterion	Required	Description
Validation	Required	During joint meetings, the members of a topic working group review the plausibility of their colleagues' recorded activities.
Deviation from the Group Average	Required	An average indicates how many hours, on average, each member of the topic working group has contributed. Each member must have contributed at least 60% of the group average.
Different Types of Activities	Required	A member may count only up to 20% of their hours toward organizational activities.
Three Types of Activities	Required	Each member must have performed at least three different types of activities, including: • Organization • Research • Prepare results ◦ Prepare a presentation ◦ Prepare an article for a professional journal ◦ Prepare a conference paper ◦ Give a presentation at a conference
Travel time does not count	Required	Travel time does not count as an activity.

Criteria for Oral Exam

Point on Agenda	Duration	Criteria
1) The examinee presents the topic with self-created resources.	10-20 min	• Results and findings conclusively summarized • Recognizable common thread, expediency, and consistency of the steps • Appropriate use of resources (charts, diagrams, models, ...) • Presentation style (language and expression) • Illustrations are legible and understandable
2) The examiners ask about the content of the results.	10-20 min	• Ability to explain and clarify the content • Answering at least three open questions • Complexity and depth of answers • Questions answered comprehensively and presented in a clear and logical manner.
3) The examiners test whether the candidate has understood the content, knows the background, and understands the context.	10-20 min	• Present their opinion well and comprehensibly in the discussion. • Statement on the criticism of the results of the topic working group.

Examiners must have the following characteristics:

- They are recognized experts in software architecture.
- They have extensive and in-depth knowledge in the field of software architecture.
- They have sufficient time to perform their work as examiners.

The iSAQB Expert Level Working Group appoints the examiners.

They work on a freelance basis as examiners for the certification bodies.